Road and play on the grounds of the New English School. The choice was between football, basketball, kho-kho and kabaddi. The school frowned on individual or elitist sports like cricket. I had to obtain special permission to go thrice a week for cricket coaching at the PYC grounds at Deccan Gymkhana. On those days, I would walk there straight after school and be able to play till about 6 p.m. This arrangement was not very satisfactory, however, and I feel I could never realize my full potential, despite having been part of the school team in Delhi.

The Saturday prayer would be led by my classmate, Nandakumar (Nandu) Koregaonkar. Nandu too joined the Army; we were coursemates too, and he was Commissioned into the First Battalion of the Parachute Regiment (1 PARA). Another classmate who joined the Army was Sarwottam Shrikant Hasabnis, who followed in his father's footsteps and joined the Jat Regiment. His father had been taken prisoner of war at Galwan during the 1962 war, the same place which was to witness bloody clashes between troops of the Chinese People's Liberation Army and our own troops in June 2020. His younger brother, Sadanand Shrikant Hasabnis, joined a year later, rose to the rank of Lieutenant General and retired as the Deputy Chief of the Army Staff. All my other classmates did equally well in their chosen fields. Milind Modak is an orthopaedist of renown. Rajeev Ranade retired as a Commissioner in the Income Tax Department. Dattatreya (Sunil) Modak has his own successful company. Vijay Inamdar worked on various defence-related projects, including the first indigenous nuclear submarine, 'Arihant'. The list of accomplishments is long. I stayed in touch with my classmates as best as possible, looking up one or the other while on leave in Pune. We were and remain a close-knit group.

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation